Restore a Deleted Release Branch from the Vault

Oct 11, 2026 · @abi

Before you start

The deleted release branch still exists in the vault. You copy it back to the normal repo as a feature branch, then turn it into the release branch in Bitbucket. Release branches can't be pushed to directly, so the feature branch is required.

Archived branches are permanently deleted from the vault after 180 days, so restore them before then.

What you need	Example	Where to find it
Vault URL	`https://bitbucket.org/mycompany/myapp-vault.git`	Vault repo in Bitbucket → **Clone**
Normal URL	`https://bitbucket.org/mycompany/myapp.git`	Normal repo in Bitbucket → **Clone**
Release branch	`release/2026.10.11`	Vault repo → **Branches** (pick the newest)
Feature branch	`feature/RESTORE-release-2026.10.11`	Any name your push hook allows
Git Bash (Windows) or Terminal (Mac)	`git --version` shows a version	Start menu / Applications

Use your Bitbucket username and app password (or token) when asked to log in, not your normal password.

Manual steps

Run these in Git Bash, one at a time. Replace the example URLs and branch names with yours.

#	Command	What you should see
1	`git clone --single-branch --branch release/2026.10.11 https://bitbucket.org/mycompany/myapp-vault.git`	`Cloning into 'myapp-vault'...` then `done`
2	`cd myapp-vault`	The prompt shows `myapp-vault`
3	`git remote set-url origin https://bitbucket.org/mycompany/myapp.git`	Nothing (that means it worked)
4	`git remote -v`	Two lines with the **normal** URL
5	`git checkout -b feature/RESTORE-release-2026.10.11`	`Switched to a new branch ...`
6	`git push -u origin feature/RESTORE-release-2026.10.11`	Upload progress, then the branch name

Step 3 uses the **normal** URL. You cloned from the vault, so this switches where the push goes.

The script

The script does the manual steps for one repo. Make one copy per repo and edit the 4 lines at the top.

1. Save the script below as `restore-myapp.sh` (one copy per repo, e.g. `restore-other.sh`).
2. Edit `VAULT_URL`, `NORMAL_URL`, `RELEASE_BRANCH` and `FEATURE_BRANCH`.
3. Run `chmod +x restore-myapp.sh` (one time only).
4. Run `./restore-myapp.sh`.
5. Finish in Bitbucket (next section).

```
#!/usr/bin/env bash
# Restore a deleted release branch from the vault (one repo).
# Make a copy of this file for each repo and edit the 4 lines below.

VAULT_URL="https://bitbucket.org/mycompany/myapp-vault.git"
```

```
NORMAL_URL="https://bitbucket.org/mycompany/myapp.git"
RELEASE_BRANCH="release/2026.10.11"
FEATURE_BRANCH="feature/RESTORE-release-2026.10.11"

# ---- no edits below ----
set -e

echo "1. Downloading $RELEASE_BRANCH from the vault..."
git clone --single-branch --branch "$RELEASE_BRANCH" "$VAULT_URL" restore-
temp
cd restore-temp

echo "2. Switching to the normal repo..."
git remote set-url origin "$NORMAL_URL"
git remote -v

echo "3. Creating $FEATURE_BRANCH..."
git checkout -b "$FEATURE_BRANCH"

echo "4. Pushing $FEATURE_BRANCH..."
git push -u origin "$FEATURE_BRANCH"

cd ..
rm -rf restore-temp

echo
echo "DONE. Now in the normal Bitbucket:"
echo "  Create branch -> From: $FEATURE_BRANCH -> Name: $RELEASE_BRANCH"
echo "  If blocked: create $RELEASE_BRANCH from master, then PR
$FEATURE_BRANCH -> $RELEASE_BRANCH and Merge"
```

Finish in Bitbucket

Try option A first. It gives an exact copy of the deleted branch with no pull request.

Option	Steps in the normal Bitbucket	Result
A. From the feature branch	**Create branch** → From: `feature/RESTORE-release-2026.10.11` → Name: `release/2026.10.11`	Exact copy, finished

Option	Steps in the normal Bitbucket	Result
B. If A is blocked	**Create branch** from `master` (or `develop`) → Name: `release/2026.10.11`, then **Pull request** `feature/RESTORE-release-2026.10.11` → `release/2026.10.11` → **Merge**	Restored through a PR
C. If both are blocked	Ask the repo admin to create `release/2026.10.11` from `feature/RESTORE-release-2026.10.11`	Admin finishes it

With option B, the PR should show only the release branch's own changes. If it shows many unrelated files, `master` has moved on: create the release branch from the commit given by `git merge-base feature/RESTORE-release-2026.10.11 origin/master` instead.

Common errors

Error	Meaning	Fix
`Remote branch ... not found`	Wrong release branch name	Check the exact name in the vault's **Branches** page
`Authentication failed`	Wrong login	Use your Bitbucket app password or token
Push `rejected` by a hook	The hook doesn't accept the feature branch name	Use the allowed format, e.g. `feature/JIRA-123-restore-release`
`destination path 'restore-temp' already exists`	A previous run stopped halfway	Delete the `restore-temp` folder and run again
`fatal: not a git repository`	You're not inside the repo folder	Run the `cd` step again